

Pedro Magaña Sáenz

Agricultural and Applied Economics, University of Wisconsin-Madison

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Education

University of Wisconsin—Madison | Wisconsin, United States

Ph.D. in Agricultural and Applied Economics

May 2026 (expected)

M.S. in Agricultural and Applied Economics

2022

University of Michigan—Ann Arbor | Michigan, United States

M.S. in Applied Economics

2019

M.A. in Public Policy

2019

Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM) | Mexico City, Mexico

B.A. in Economics

2012

Working papers

Signed, Sealed, Delivered: Digital Receipts in the Ugandan Dairy Chain (Job Market Paper)

with David J. Henning

We provide causal evidence that digital receipts—SMS messages reporting milk—can improve accountability, delivery behavior, and product quality in agricultural markets. In a randomized experiment with dairy cooperatives in western Uganda, we find that treated farmers—particularly those who self-deliver—are significantly more likely to deliver milk. This increase in delivery activity occurs without a change in average volumes delivered, suggesting a shift along the extensive margin. The intervention also improves milk quality: treated farmers deliver higher-quality (less diluted) milk, as measured by lactometer readings. Among farmers who rely on transporters, digital receipts increase the likelihood of detecting discrepancies, switching baseline transporters, and reporting lower trust in transporters. These results show that the intervention works differently depending on whether information frictions are present: for self-deliverers, who already have full observability over their deliveries, impacts are concentrated on participation, while for transporter users, where observability is limited, impacts are concentrated on detecting discrepancies and moving away from dishonest transporters. By turning unobservable transactions into verifiable digital records, SMS receipts enhance transparency and make intermediary behavior more observable. Overall, our findings show how simple digital tools can reduce information frictions, shift farmer and intermediary behavior, and improve product quality in fragmented agricultural systems.

Banking Amidst Conflict: How Violence Shapes Financial Inclusion in Mexico

with Xiaofei Wang

We investigate how conflict influences the use of formal financial services in Mexico. Using police reports and death records from the Ministry of Health, we construct municipality-level forecasts of expected violence from 2011 to 2020. Deviations from these forecasts—months with unexpectedly high violence—serve as proxies for unanticipated public safety shocks. We then study how these localized, time-specific episodes affect individuals' use of financial services, distinguishing between traditional banking channels and non-traditional outlets. Our analysis leverages administrative transaction data from the National Banking and Securities Commission, covering all municipalities in Mexico over the same period. We also examine whether security concerns accelerate the adoption of digital financial tools as a risk mitigation strategy. By focusing on behavioral responses to violence—rather than long-run correlations—we shed light on the indirect transaction costs of insecurity and the adaptive strategies households use to navigate fragile environments. This research contributes to the growing literature on financial inclusion in conflict-affected settings and offers insights for designing more resilient financial systems in the face of localized violence.

Work in progress

Aligning Incentives through Digital Monitoring: Evidence from the Ugandan Dairy Sector
From Prayer to Progress: Religious Festivals and Development in Mexico

Research & Professional Experience

Research Assistant, University of Wisconsin Madison, Wisconsin <i>Professors: Dr. Dustin Frye, Dr. Corbett Grainger, and Dr. Bradford Barham</i>	2021 – Present
Research Assistant, University of Michigan Ann Arbor, Michigan <i>Professors: Dr. Eduardo Montero and Dr. Zach Y. Brown</i>	Spring 2020
Research Assistant, Center on Finance, Law and Policy, University of Michigan Ann Arbor, Michigan <i>Professors: Michael Barr, J.D.; Dr. Antoinette Schoar, and Dr. Eldar Shafir</i>	Fall 2019
Research Assistant, Northwestern University Chicago, Illinois <i>Professors: Dr. Erika Deserranno and Dr. Gianmarco Leon-Ciliotta</i>	Summer 2019
Research Associate, University of Michigan Ann Arbor, Michigan <i>Conducted market research and provided financial and technical support to SMEs</i>	2018 – 2019
Research Assistant, University of Michigan Ann Arbor, Michigan <i>Professors: Dr. Dean Yang; Dr. Xavier Giné, and Dr. Jessica Goldberg</i>	2017 – 2018
Country Office Intern, Innovations for Poverty Action Lilongwe, Malawi <i>Professors: Dr. Dean Yang; Dr. Xavier Giné, and Dr. Jessica Goldberg</i>	Summer 2017
Economic Analysis Coordinator, Ministry of Finance Mexico City, Mexico <i>Developed and monitored venture capital investments in agribusiness</i>	2014 – 2016
Market Analyst, Laureate International Universities Mexico City, Mexico <i>Developed statistical models to assess the impact of price changes on consumer behavior</i>	2013 – 2014
Financial Analyst, Laureate International Universities Mexico City, Mexico <i>Led analytical reporting on fixed asset budgets and forecasts for the CFO</i>	2012 – 2013
Research Coordinator, Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM) Mexico City, Mexico <i>Professors: Dr. Enrique Seira and Dr. Joyce Sadka</i>	2011 – 2012
Parliamentary Advisor, Senate of Mexico Mexico City, Mexico <i>Advised senator on the economic viability of proposed legislation</i>	2010 – 2011

Research Grants

The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics – University of Chicago, \$15,000 USD <i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>	2025
International Growth Centre (IGC) – Agri-SME Evidence Fund, £20,000 GBP <i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>	2024
The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics – University of Chicago, \$15,000 USD <i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>	2023
J-PAL/CEGA – Digital Agricultural Innovations and Services (DAISI) Initiative , \$71,000 USD <i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>	2023

International Growth Centre (IGC) – Small Project Facility, £20,000 GBP 2022
 Role: **PI** – with David J. Henning

Honors and Awards

AAEA Travel Grant – Agricultural & Applied Economics Association (AAEA) 2025
 Thomsen Distinguished Graduate Dissertator Fellowship (nominated) – University of Wisconsin—Madison 2024
 AAE Dissertator Research Award – University of Wisconsin—Madison, \$1,000 USD 2024
 Barbara and Thomas Lyon Scholarship, \$4,000 USD, University of Wisconsin—Madison. 2023
 UW-Madison Travel Grant, \$1,500 USD, University of Wisconsin—Madison 2022
 Outstanding Teaching Assistant Award, University of Wisconsin—Madison 2021 – 2022
 Rackham International Student Fellowship, \$10,000 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor. 2019
 Annenberg Internship, \$7,500 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor 2017
 Ford School Fellowship, \$2,500 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor 2017

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, University of Wisconsin | Madison, Wisconsin
AAE 474/ECON 474: Economic Problems of Developing Areas Fall 2025
AAE 350: World Hunger and Malnutrition Spring 2022
MATH 221: Calculus and Analytic Geometry II Fall 2020

 Teaching Assistant, University of Michigan | Ann Arbor, Michigan
PUBPOL 639: Quantitative Methods for Program Evaluation Spring 2019
POLSCI 369: International Economic Relations Fall 2018
PUBPOL 639: Quantitative Methods for Program Evaluation Spring 2018
POLSCI 490: Game Theory and Formal Models Fall 2017

Pre-Doctoral Publications

Magaña Sáenz, P.F. (2015). Behavioral Economics and Nudges Applied to Pawnshops. **Gaceta de Economía**, 34, 96-126. (Original in Spanish)

Talks

2025 AFE 2025 (University of Chicago), AAEA/WAEA Joint Annual Meeting,
 Juli Plant Grainger Public Workshop, Applied Economics Workshop (University of Wisconsin)
 2024 Development Workshop, Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)
 2023 Development Workshop, Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)
 2022 Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)
 2021 Development Lab (University of Wisconsin)

Affiliations

Graduate Research Fellow, Institute for Research on Poverty 2025 – 2026

Other Information

Languages: Spanish (Native), English (Fluent)

Skills: Stata (Advanced), L^AT_EX(Advanced), Microsoft Office (Advanced), R (Intermediate), Python (Intermediate)

References

Laura Schechter
Vilas Distinguished Achievement Professor
Department of Economics
University of Wisconsin—Madison
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1180 Observatory Drive
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